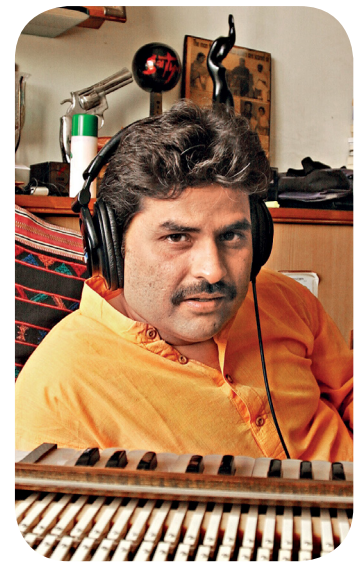
Rangeela

1995 (A.R. Rahman)

Rahman's first original Hindi film score gives him a playground big enough to show his mastery and range. Mehboob's refreshing, unconventional lyrics complemented ARR's complex, auteur-level compositions to give us teens of the '90s a blood rush like nothing before. From the trippy, seductive theme music to Suresh Wadkar's brooding Pyaar Ye, *Shweta Shetty-ARR's positively goofy* Maangta Hai Kya, *Swarnalatha's sinful* Hai Raama *and Asha's flighty groove in* Tanha Tanha, *the vibe and tempo shift with balletic elegance.*



HEMANT PITHWA



BHASKAR PAUL

Maachis

1996 (Vishal Bhardwaj)

Vishal Bhardwaj arrived on the film music scene with an album that felt like a woollen quilt on a dark, wintry night. *Chappa Chappa* and *Chhod Aaye* became youth anthems. The five Lata Mangeshkar gems, all strung on the pain in her voice, go from elegiac to longing-filled. Gulzar saab's words (*Gori chatkori*, *Bhej kahaar*, *Ik andha kuaan*), adding depth and mood to an already smouldering album, made it a cult favourite of the '90s.

Oye Lucky! Lucky Oye!

2008 (Sneha Khanwalkar)

Sadly, the only female composer in this list—a statement on how patriarchal the music industry has been, and how difficult for women—Khanwalkar's debut score is the most innovative album of the past two decades. Fusion raginis (*Tu raja ki raaj dulari*), improvised folk (*Jugni*), rap (*Superchor*), and a conventional saucy bhangra (*Oye Lucky*) come together to not just elevate the cool quotient of Dibakar Banerjee's 2008 dramedy but mint an all-new film music aesthetic that Sneha went on to mine later.



GETTY IMAGES

Dev.D

2009 (Amit Trivedi)

Another debut, another home run. Amit Trivedi and Amitabh Bhattacharya (with Shellee, Anusha Mani and Shruti Pathak) collaborated on this Anurag Kashyap musical—the album, high on both style and substance, lists 18 tracks! The high points, of course, are *Emosanal Atyachaar* and *Saali Khushi*, both cutting deep into the persecution complex-ridden youth psyche of the times. Tracks like *Payaaliya* (written and sung by Shruti Pathak), *Dhol Yaara Dhol* and *Maahi Nainu* (both written by Shellee) add a strong folk-fusion dimension to a soundtrack that careens playfully from Dixieland to edgier tones.

MANDAR DEODHAR

